

Phase 0 Operating Blueprint

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Phase 0 operating blueprint — cheapest possible Dubbo eWaste start

Updated: 2 October 2026

Scope: a very small, selective electronics reuse/refurbishment business operated from a leased residential shed in Dubbo, with intake on Tuesdays and Saturdays.

Goal: prove that good electronics can be sourced, securely processed and profitably reused before taking on warehouse rent, staff, a truck, broad e-waste intake or industrial recycling.

Core principle: reuse first, recycle second.
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Phase 0 is not intended to be a general public tip, scrap yard, battery drop point or industrial e-waste processing facility.

The exact residential address is intentionally omitted because this repository is public.

Executive conclusion

A very cheap start still looks possible, but the cheapest safe and defensible version is narrower than simply putting up a sign saying “e-waste accepted Tuesdays and Saturdays”.

The best Phase 0 model is:

1. Pre-screen every item before it arrives.
2. Accept only electronics with an identified reuse, refurbishment, parts or legitimate downstream pathway.
3. Have no unattended drop-off and no public waste bin.
4. Reject the item at the door if it fails the acceptance test — the person bringing it keeps it.
5. Keep public visits low-volume and controlled.
6. Sell mainly online, with controlled collection/delivery, rather than operating a walk-in retail shop at the house.
7. Keep all accepted stock inside, dry, secure and out of public view.
8. Put every data-bearing device into a secure UNWIPED workflow immediately.
9. Do not accept loose lithium batteries or damaged/swollen/wet/fire-affected battery devices during Phase 0.
10. Use established product-stewardship/commercial recyclers for material that cannot be reused.
11. Do not start public intake until Council has confirmed the planning classification, Fair Trading has answered the second-hand-dealer exemption question, and the insurer/landlord position is understood.
12. Do not use the existing shed for valuable electronics inventory until its moisture/water/mould suitability is resolved.

The cheapest model is therefore selective electronics rescue/refurbishment with controlled intake, not “take any e-waste”.

1. Why Phase 0 needs to be selective

The mature Bendigo E-Waste operation is not the correct starting benchmark. Joe's own published history says he began by handling his own e-waste and then equipment from friends and family before the business grew.

For Dubbo, the equivalent early-stage experiment is:

personal technical capability → known-source equipment → selective local intake → reuse/refurbish/resell → learn the economics → expand only when proven

The project does not need, at launch:

- a warehouse
- a truck
- employees
- pallets or commercial cages
- 24/7 public drop-off
- industrial shredding
- a battery collection program
- broad whitegoods intake
- large amounts of scrap
- a retail showroom
- a custom app
- a large stock purchase
- a Council e-waste contract

The economic question in Phase 0 is not “how many tonnes can we collect?” It is:

Of every 10 items accepted, how many can be reused, repaired or parted profitably without creating a storage or disposal liability?

2. The biggest legal/planning question: what is the activity?

This is the most important unresolved question.

2.1 A home business can potentially be exempt development

NSW Planning guidance says a residential property can be used for a home-based business as exempt development if the relevant standards are met. It can be carried out in an ancillary building such as a detached garage or studio.

The NSW standard planning definition of home business requires, among other things:

- the business is carried on by permanent residents
- no more than two non-resident employees
- no neighbourhood amenity interference from noise, fumes, waste products, traffic generation or similar impacts
- no unsightly matter visible from neighbouring premises or public places
- only a business identification sign
- no ordinary on-site retail sale/exposure of goods not produced there, except online retailing

Dubbo Regional LEP 2022 further limits a home business to 30 m² of floor area.

This is why online sales, controlled customer arrivals and hidden/contained stock are important.

Sources

- NSW Planning Portal — Home-based enterprises:

<https://www.planningportal.nsw.gov.au/development-and-assessment/planning-approval-pathways/exempt-development/home-based-enterprises>

- Standard Instrument definition — home business:

<https://legislation.nsw.gov.au/>

- Dubbo Regional Local Environmental Plan 2022, cl 5.4:

<https://legislation.nsw.gov.au/>

2.2 But the same activity may be characterised differently

NSW planning legislation also defines goods repair and reuse premises as premises whose principal purpose is to collect, repair or refurbish goods, including appliances, for sale, hire or swap.

That description is uncomfortably close to the proposed model.

There is also a waste/resource risk. The NSW EPA has made clear that unwanted material can be waste even where a business intends to sort/recover value from it. In July 2026, the EPA publicised a \$30,000 fine against a scrap-metal recycler that accepted old cars and other waste and separated/sorted it; the EPA said this met the definition of a waste facility. The EPA also expressly said businesses processing less than the EPL threshold could still require development consent.

This means staying below EPA tonnage thresholds does not automatically make the shed use lawful.

Sources

- NSW definition — goods repair and reuse premises:

<https://legislation.nsw.gov.au/>

- NSW EPA, “Unlawful waste facility hit with \$30,000 fine”, 21 July 2026:

<https://www.epa.nsw.gov.au/news/epamedia/260721-unlawful-waste-facility-hit-with-30-000-fine>

- NSW EPA licensing thresholds:

<https://www.epa.nsw.gov.au/Your-environment/Waste/waste-overview/licensing/reduced-licensing-thresholds>

2.3 The Council question must be asked very specifically

Do not ask only:

“Can I run an e-waste business from home?”

That wording invites the broadest/worst-case interpretation.

Instead describe the actual Phase 0 operation accurately:

I am considering a small home-based electronics reuse/refurbishment activity from an existing ancillary shed. I would be the only worker initially. I would pre-approve devices before arrival and accept only small quantities of reusable or repairable laptops, phones, tablets, computers, monitors, selected flat-panel TVs and similar electronics. There would be no public waste bin, no unattended dumping, no outdoor stockpile, no shredding, no bulk scrap processing, no loose battery collection and no walk-in retail showroom. Customer intake would be limited to Tuesdays and Saturdays, with low traffic and one customer at a time where practical. Sales would principally be online. Unaccepted items would remain with the person who brought them. The operating area would remain under 30 m². How would Council classify this activity and is it exempt development, permitted with consent, or prohibited at this property?

Ask for the answer in writing if possible.

Gating rule

No advertised public intake until Council answers this.

3. The lease and the actual shed are separate gating issues

Planning approval and the residential tenancy agreement are different questions.

3.1 Lease restrictions found

A review of the current residential tenancy agreement found no general clause expressly saying “no business” or “no commercial activity”.

However:

- clause 16 prohibits illegal use, nuisance, interference with neighbours' reasonable peace/comfort/privacy, and negligent or intentional damage
- clause 86 says a garage/car-space is for parking a motor vehicle only and not for storage of personal goods
- clause 87 says a storage room/cage/area is not warranted by the landlord as fit for purpose, adequately ventilated, secure or watertight

Therefore the exact physical/legal character of the intended workspace matters. Do not assume that an area colloquially called “the shed” is unrestricted simply because the lease does not contain a blanket business ban.

3.2 The current shed-condition evidence matters

Existing tenancy records document mould/water-damage concerns in the garage/shed and previously recorded unresolved moisture/remediation issues.

That creates a practical business problem even before legal questions:

- moisture damages laptops, TVs, PCBs, connectors and packaging
- mould-contaminated inventory is difficult to safely resell
- high humidity can accelerate corrosion
- water ingress increases electrical/fire risk
- valuable client data-bearing devices should not be stored in an insecure/wet area

Phase 0 premises rule

Do not hold resale stock or unwiped client devices in the shed until it is demonstrably dry, secure and suitable.

This is one reason the true zero-dollar first phase should be research + pre-screening + systems, not immediately accumulating inventory.

4. Tuesday/Saturday opening model

The user requirement is to operate on Tuesdays and Saturdays. The cheapest/lowest-impact interpretation is not “shop open all day”.

Recommended Phase 0 model

Public wording

Tuesday & Saturday intake — pre-approval required.
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Reusable and repairable electronics only.

Send photos/model/details first.

No dumping. We reserve the right to refuse any item.
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Do not publish fixed long opening hours until Council/insurer feedback is received.

Intake mechanics

Use a free web/social form or messages to collect:

- item category
- brand/model
- clear photos
- does it power on?
- known fault
- cracked screen/panel?
- battery swollen/damaged?

- wet/fire damaged?
- account/activation lock status
- charger included?
- quantity
- suburb/source
- whether it contains business/customer data

Then send one of:

- ACCEPT — bring Tuesday/Saturday
- ACCEPT SUBJECT TO INSPECTION
- REJECT
- NEED MORE INFORMATION

At the property

- one customer vehicle at a time where practical
- no queue
- no browsing showroom
- no after-hours pile
- no “leave it at the gate”
- no outside cage/bin
- no pallets/truck deliveries initially
- no equipment visible from street after intake
- rejected devices leave with the donor
- close intake when storage cap is reached

Why this is useful

It reduces:

- traffic
- neighbour impact
- dumping
- low-value stock
- waste classification risk
- battery risk
- disposal cost
- storage pressure

It also makes the two opening days useful without pretending to be a full retail premises.

5. Phase 0 acceptance policy

The phrase “high-quality old electronics” needs an objective internal test.

The four-gate test

Accept an item only if it passes all applicable gates.

Gate A — legal/ownership

Can the person reasonably transfer ownership?

For prescribed second-hand goods, the final record requirements depend on whether the second-hand dealer licensing regime applies. Even if exempt, keep an ownership-transfer record.

Reject where:

- ownership is suspicious or disputed
- serial/IMEI is deliberately removed/defaced without credible explanation
- person will not provide required transfer details
- device is organisation-managed and authorisation cannot be established

Gate B — safety

Reject where:

- battery is swollen, bulging, leaking, punctured, crushed, overheating, smoking, fire-affected or water-affected
- TV/monitor has a badly cracked panel creating handling risk
- mains cable/plug/power supply is visibly unsafe and there is no safe reason to retain the unit for parts
- contamination, pests, biological contamination or heavy grime make handling unreasonable
- item is recalled/banned in a way that prevents safe lawful resale and no specific safe recycling pathway is intended

Gate C — technical/value

There must be at least one credible route:

1. resale substantially as-is
2. economical repair/refurbishment
3. known-use donor parts
4. collector/vintage value
5. confirmed downstream recycling path with acceptable cost

If none applies, reject it.

Gate D — storage

There must be a defined shelf/bin location before acceptance.

If the relevant shelf is full, intake stops.

This simple rule is better than accepting everything and discovering later that the shed has become a waste stockpile.

6. Device-by-device acceptance rules

6.1 Laptops and small PCs — priority category

Strong Phase 0 accepts

- business-class laptops and mini PCs
- recent quality consumer laptops
- MacBooks with Activation Lock removed
- systems with SSD/RAM/chargers that are useful even if repair is needed
- physically complete machines with intact displays/hinges unless a known donor part makes them worthwhile

2026 software-support gate

Windows 10 reached normal end of support on 14 October 2025. Microsoft recommends Windows 11 on eligible devices.

Therefore:

- default retail target: Windows 11-compatible hardware
- older non-Windows-11 PCs: only accept where there is another viable pathway — Linux, vintage/collector, donor parts, specific low-cost use, or downstream recycling
- do not assume “it runs Windows 10” means it is a strong retail refurb in late 2026

No arbitrary CPU-generation cutoff should replace actual compatibility/value checking, because unusual/vintage/higher-end hardware can still have value.

Source:

- Microsoft — Windows 10 end of support:

<https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/deployment/updates-lifecycle/windows-10-support-has-ended-on-october-14-2025>

6.2 Phones

Accept only when

- screen/body is economically viable
- battery shows no damage/swelling
- device is not water/fire damaged
- donor can remove Apple Activation Lock / account lock
- Android protection/account state can be properly cleared
- IMEI/serial can be recorded
- model remains practically usable on Australian networks

Australian network gate

Australia's 3G shutdown means 3G-only phones and some older 4G phones cannot operate properly; devices that cannot make emergency calls over the post-3G networks may be blocked by carriers.

So for phones:

- do not accept merely because the device powers on
- confirm current Australian network/VoLTE/000 compatibility before resale
- do not advertise a phone as network-compatible without testing/verification appropriate to the device/carrier

Source:

- ACMA — 3G network switch-off / emergency-call compatibility:

<https://www.acma.gov.au/3g-network-switch>

6.3 Apple devices

Activation Lock must be removed before the donor leaves whenever practical.

Apple says Activation Lock must be removed so another person can activate the device.

Do not build the business around bypassing account locks.

Source:

- Apple — remove Activation Lock:

<https://support.apple.com/en-au/108934>

6.4 Android devices

Factory-reset protection can prevent reuse after reset if the prior account cannot be verified. Treat an Android phone/tablet that cannot be legitimately cleared as a poor resale candidate.

At intake, where appropriate:

- have owner unlock device
- remove Google/other manufacturer accounts as required
- then perform the controlled wipe/reset later
- never ask the donor to hand over their account password for you to retain

Source:

- Google Android Help — device protection / ownership verification after factory reset:

<https://support.google.com/android/answer/9459346>

6.5 Tablets

Use the phone rules plus:

- verify usable battery condition

- verify current OS/app viability
- reject locked devices
- reject cracked/bent battery-bearing units unless there is a clearly safe donor-parts pathway

Note: tablets are generally not within MobileMuster's ordinary accepted categories, so they need a separate downstream route.

6.6 TVs

TVs are a dangerous category economically because they consume substantial space and damaged panels are often worth very little.

Phase 0 rule: TVs by prior approval only

Accept where:

- flat-panel only
- identifiable brand/model
- intact panel
- no fire/water damage
- known fault is plausibly economic to repair, or
- unit works and has a resale path
- storage location exists before arrival

Reject initially:

- CRT televisions/monitors
- cracked panels
- heavily damaged cases
- unknown large dead TVs without a known parts/recycling path
- anything too large to safely store/handle with available equipment

Do not make TV repair involving hazardous mains sections a casual learning activity. If the fault requires work beyond demonstrated competence, use a qualified repairer or recycle the unit.

6.7 Desktops/components

Good accepts include:

- complete desktops/mini PCs
- GPUs
- quality PSUs with known history/testability
- SSDs/RAM
- motherboards/CPU's with identified value
- OEM power supplies/chargers that can be safely matched

Avoid accumulating:

- generic dead cases
- obsolete low-value boards with no buyer
- boxes of unsorted cables
- no-name PSUs/chargers of uncertain compliance

6.8 Other electronics

Accept only after pre-approval where the route is known, e.g.:

- game consoles
- cameras
- quality audio
- vintage computing
- networking equipment
- specialised electronics with collector/repair value

“Electronic” is not enough. The business needs a route to value.

7. Phase 0 reject list

Until the business has specific downstream and safety systems, reject:

- CRT TVs/monitors
- cracked-panel TVs unless a specific profitable parts route is already known
- loose lithium batteries
- swollen/bulging/leaking/punctured/crushed/overheated batteries
- fire-affected devices
- water-submerged battery devices
- vapes/e-cigarettes
- large whitegoods
- printers/scanners unless specifically pre-approved
- fluorescent lamps
- smoke alarms
- random boxes of mixed cables
- generic no-name chargers
- contaminated/pest-infested equipment
- unidentified business IT without authority to transfer it
- Apple devices with unresolved Activation Lock
- Android devices that cannot be legitimately unlocked/reset for reuse
- 3G-only/incompatible phones except where specifically accepted for parts/recycling
- bulk dead low-value electronics
- anything with no identified exit route

A good Phase 0 rule is:

If we cannot explain what we will probably do with it before it enters the shed, we do not accept it.

8. Lithium-ion battery policy

This deserves its own strict rule because it is one of the largest physical risks of a home electronics operation.

Fire and Rescue NSW identifies damaged batteries as including units that are:

- swollen/bulging
- leaking
- cracked/dented/punctured/crushed
- overheated
- wet/submerged
- fire exposed

FRNSW says never use or charge a damaged battery.

B-cycle also says badly damaged/swollen batteries must not be put in an ordinary B-cycle drop point.

Cheapest Phase 0 policy

Do

- inspect battery-bearing devices before acceptance
- reject visibly damaged battery devices
- use correct/compliant chargers only
- charge/test on a hard non-combustible surface away from combustible stock
- supervise charging
- stop testing at abnormal heat/smell/swelling
- have smoke/heat detection appropriate to the space
- maintain a written emergency action
- use an accredited downstream collector for battery waste when necessary

Do not

- advertise battery recycling
- accept loose household batteries
- become a public B-cycle site yet
- charge devices overnight or while nobody is present
- open/rebuild lithium packs as part of Phase 0
- accumulate "batteries to deal with later"

Becoming a B-cycle public drop point requires an accredited collector, container protocols, site risk assessment and safety plan. There is no reason to add this complexity during the cheapest pilot.

Sources:

- Fire and Rescue NSW:

<https://www.fire.nsw.gov.au/fire-safety/home-fire-safety/battery-and-charging-safety/what-should-i-do-if-my-battery-is-damaged>

- B-cycle:

<https://bcycle.com.au/>

- B-cycle drop-point requirements:

<https://bcycle.com.au/register/>

9. Intake chain of custody

Every accepted item gets an ID immediately.

Example:

DEW-2026-0001

Minimum intake record

- intake ID
- date/time
- source/customer
- transfer type: donated / purchased / business disposal / other
- make/model
- serial number
- IMEI where applicable
- device category
- visible condition
- battery condition
- charger/accessories
- powers on? yes/no/not tested
- account/activation-lock status
- data-bearing? yes/no/unknown
- stated known faults
- owner statement / authority to transfer
- intended initial route
- photo(s)

If Fair Trading confirms that a second-hand dealer licence applies, update this workflow to every prescribed statutory field and reporting requirement.

Ownership statement

The transfer form should say, in plain language, that the person:

- owns the item or is authorised to transfer it
- transfers ownership to the operating legal entity
- has removed/backed up anything they wish to keep
- understands data will be erased or media may be destroyed
- has disclosed known battery damage and major faults
- understands acceptance is subject to inspection

Do not claim that an ownership declaration magically cures suspicious provenance. Reject suspicious items.

10. Data-bearing devices — secure workflow

Data handling should be one of the project's strongest differentiators.

Physical zones

Every data-bearing device begins in:

UNWIPED — RESTRICTED

It may not move to repair, parts or sale status until data handling is complete.

Basic workflow

1. Intake

- assign asset ID
- record serial/IMEI
- identify storage media
- record lock/account status

2. Account handover

- donor removes Apple/Google/organisation locks where required
- donor retains their credentials; do not store passwords

3. Secure storage

- unwiped devices kept separately and securely
- no casual family/visitor access

4. Sanitisation

- use method appropriate to media type
- HDD, SSD/NVMe, phones/tablets and soldered storage need different approaches
- follow current manufacturer/ASD guidance rather than assuming one overwrite method works for everything

5. Verification

- verify the erasure/reset outcome
- confirm device reaches clean setup state where applicable

6. Record

- date
- operator
- tool/method
- result
- failed media/destruction outcome if relevant

7. Status change

- label SANITISED
- only then move to repair/resale/parts workflow

HDD/SSD caution

The Australian Cyber Security Centre notes that SSDs may require manufacturer-specific erasure steps. ASD's current media sanitisation guidance should be the baseline for higher-assurance work.

Do not advertise a simplistic “7-pass wipe” as superior. Modern sanitisation should be media-appropriate and verifiable.

Marketing language

Phase 0 can honestly offer:

Documented secure data erasure

Avoid saying:

certified data destruction

unless the business later adopts a process/accreditation that supports that exact claim.

Sources:

- Australian Cyber Security Centre — disposing of devices securely:

<https://www.cyber.gov.au/protect-yourself/securing-your-devices/how-secure-your-device/how-dispose-your-device-securely>

- ASD ISM — media guidelines:

<https://www.cyber.gov.au/business-government/asds-cyber-security-frameworks/ism/cyber-security-guidelines/guidelines-for-media>

- NIST SP 800-88 Rev. 2 (2025):

<https://csrc.nist.gov/pubs/sp/800/88/r2/final>

11. Shed layout — cheapest controlled system

Do not buy elaborate warehouse infrastructure.

Use existing shelving/tubs where safe, but create clearly labelled zones.

Suggested zones

1. INTAKE / UNASSESSED
2. UNWIPE — RESTRICTED
3. TEST / REPAIR
4. READY FOR SALE
5. DONOR / PARTS
6. OUTBOUND RECYCLING
7. QUARANTINE / STOP — for an item discovered to have a safety issue after intake

Battery-bearing devices should be handled under the specific battery SOP rather than dumped into mixed tubs.

Storage rules

- nothing on the floor where water ingress could reach it
- no outdoor stockpiles
- no devices against visibly damp surfaces
- no towers of unstable TVs
- no stock visible from street/neighbours
- no unknown items without asset ID
- no “miscellaneous pile”
- use FIFO where practical
- each zone has a physical capacity
- when a zone is full, stop accepting that category

The capacity rule costs nothing and prevents the business becoming a storage problem.

Current-property caution

Because existing tenancy records document prior shed moisture/mould/water-damage concerns, the dry-storage standard must be demonstrated rather than assumed.

12. Testing and refurbishment standard

The goal is not an expensive certification lab. It is a repeatable, recorded minimum test before resale.

Laptop/desktop checklist

Record as applicable:

- identity/serial matches intake
- visual chassis inspection
- power-on/POST
- BIOS/UEFI accessible
- CPU/RAM/storage correctly detected
- storage health
- memory test/sanity test
- battery health/cycle data where available
- charger type/rating
- keyboard/trackpad
- display/dead pixels/damage
- webcam/mic/speakers
- Wi-Fi/Bluetooth
- USB/USB-C
- Ethernet where present
- HDMI/DisplayPort
- charging
- thermal/fan behaviour under load
- sleep/wake
- clean OS setup/updates
- Windows 11 compatibility where sold as Windows PC
- recall/product-safety check
- cosmetic grade
- known faults

Phone/tablet checklist

- IMEI/serial recorded
- account/activation lock removed
- Australian network compatibility where relevant
- display/touch
- cameras
- microphones/speakers
- charging
- Wi-Fi/Bluetooth
- SIM/eSIM as appropriate
- buttons/biometrics
- battery condition/health where available
- factory reset/clean setup verified
- recall/safety check
- cosmetic grade

TV/monitor checklist

- exact model/serial
- panel physically intact
- power-on
- image/backlight
- ports
- audio
- remote/buttons
- abnormal heat/smell
- recall check
- known defects disclosed

If a mains-powered product's electrical safety is uncertain, do not sell it until appropriately assessed.

13. Resale rules and Australian Consumer Law

The business is not a private Marketplace seller once it is routinely selling refurbished inventory in trade or commerce.

NSW/ACCC guidance confirms consumer guarantees apply to second-hand goods sold by a business, taking account of age, price and condition.

A blanket:

NO REFUNDS / SOLD AS IS

does not remove statutory consumer rights.

Phase 0 sale record

Every sale should include:

- business/legal seller identity
- sale date
- invoice/receipt
- asset/serial number
- make/model/spec
- condition grade
- battery information where relevant
- known defects
- included charger/accessories
- price
- buyer details where legally required
- test date

- OS/support caveat where relevant

NSW says a receipt must be supplied for transactions of \$75 or more; under-\$75 customers can request one.

Condition grades

Use a small consistent scheme, for example:

- A — Excellent: fully functional, light cosmetic wear
- B — Good: fully functional, normal cosmetic wear
- C — Functional / disclosed wear: fully functional for stated purpose, heavier cosmetic wear or specifically disclosed limitation
- Parts/repair: only where the exact fault/unknowns are clearly described and it is lawful/safe to supply

Do not use “refurbished” unless meaningful refurbishment/testing has actually occurred.

Product safety

Before listing:

- search current Australian recalls
- verify relevant electrical compliance/approval markings
- use safe compatible chargers/power supplies
- don't sell recalled/unsafe/banned goods
- disclose faults clearly
- keep enough customer information to contact buyers if a later safety problem emerges

Sources:

- NSW — second-hand electrical goods safety:

<https://www.nsw.gov.au/housing-and-construction/safety-home/electrical-safety/buying-and-using-electrical-appliances>

- ACCC Product Safety — selling safe second-hand products online:

<https://www.productsafety.gov.au/business/know-how-to-sell-safe-products/how-to-sell-safe-second-hand-products-online>

- NSW — consumer guarantees:

<https://www.nsw.gov.au/legal-and-justice/consumer-rights-and-protection/guarantees-contracts-and-warranties/consumer-guarantees>

14. Second-hand dealer licensing

This remains unresolved and must not be guessed.

NSW Fair Trading says:

- a second-hand dealer licence is generally needed for a business buying, selling or exchanging prescribed second-hand goods
- electronic goods are prescribed

- however, a licence is not needed to “engage in recycling and rubbish collection programs”

The exact issue is whether a model whose intake is framed as electronics reuse/recycling but whose best units are refurbished and resold falls within that exemption.

Cost if required — 2026-27

- 1 year: \$692
- 3 years: \$1,574
- 5 years: \$2,456

If required, the licence changes operations significantly

Current NSW guidance includes obligations around:

- notified business/storage premises
- signs
- supplier identity/title
- electronic transaction records
- Police reporting
- retention of records
- holding periods for prescribed goods

Therefore:

Do not design the final intake database until Fair Trading answers whether the licence applies.

If an existing IT business is proposed as the operating entity, confirm:

- exact legal entity
- whether it already holds a relevant licence
- whether the Dubbo premises can/should be notified
- who owns incoming stock
- who receives sale revenue
- insurance
- liability
- tax
- conflict-of-interest/employment permission

Branding Dubbo eWaste under another company's name does not itself transfer legal coverage.

Sources:

- NSW Fair Trading — licence requirements/exemptions:

<https://www.nsw.gov.au/business-and-economy/running-a-business/industry-specific-business-requirements/pawnbrokers-and-second-hand-dealers/pawnbroker-and-second-hand-dealer-licences>

- NSW Fair Trading — 2026-27 fees:

<https://www.nsw.gov.au/business-and-economy/running-a-business/industry-specific-business-requirements/pawnbrokers-and-second-hand-dealers/pawnbrokers-and-second-hand-dealers-fees>

- NSW Fair Trading — operating obligations:

<https://www.nsw.gov.au/business-and-economy/running-a-business/industry-specific-business-requirements/pawnbrokers-and-second-hand-dealers>

15. Scrap-metal registration

NSW Police says a business carrying on a business of dealing in scrap metal must be registered. Current fee: \$260 every three years.

The 2024 amendments explicitly contemplate scrap-metal businesses operating from residential premises, so being at home is not itself an exemption.

Cheapest Phase 0 choice

Do not make scrap dealing part of the business model at launch.

- do not advertise “we buy scrap”
- do not pay for scrap metal
- do not build revenue assumptions around commodity scrap
- send unusable electronics to a legitimate downstream e-waste service

Reassess if later volumes make separated scrap a regular business activity.

Source:

- NSW Police — Scrap Metal Industry:

https://www.police.nsw.gov.au/online_services/scrap_metal_industry

16. Downstream recycling — design it before intake

An item's exit should be known before accepting it.

16.1 TVs, computers, printers and computer peripherals

Australia's National Television and Computer Recycling Scheme (NCRS) provides households and small businesses free access to industry-funded recycling for eligible televisions/computer products.

This is promising for Phase 0, but “NCRS exists” is not the same as “Dubbo eWaste can drop unlimited commercial stock anywhere for free”.

Confirm the exact local service/partner terms.

Approved co-regulatory arrangements as of May 2026 include:

- Ecoactiv / Activ Group
- TechCollect / ANZRP

- Ecocycle
- Ecycle Solutions
- Sustainable Product Stewards

TechCollect publicly says partnership with qualifying councils/waste organisations/selected business partners can include collection units, transport, recycling, signage and training at no partner cost.

Questions to ask

- Will you accept a small refurb/reuse business as a collection partner?
- Is Dubbo in your pickup network?
- minimum quantity?
- cage/bin supplied?
- complete units only?
- loose parts?
- printers?
- flat-panel TVs?
- CRTs?
- whole devices with embedded lithium batteries?
- batteries removed?
- transport cost?
- recycling certificates/reporting?
- what happens if volumes are low?

Sources:

- DCCEEW — NTCRS:

<https://www.dcceew.gov.au/environment/protection/waste/product-stewardship/television-computer-recycling-scheme>

- DCCEEW — approved co-regulatory arrangements:

<https://www.dcceew.gov.au/environment/protection/waste/product-stewardship/products-schemes/television-computer-recycling-scheme/coreg-arrangements>

- TechCollect partnership:

<https://techcollect.com.au/our-partners/partner-with-us/>

16.2 Phones

MobileMuster is the official mobile phone recycling program and offers registered sites/workplaces free pickup.

It accepts mobile phones, chargers and accessories; ordinary MobileMuster collections do not generally cover tablets or unrelated electronics.

This makes it a strong likely downstream path for truly dead phones once the participation terms are confirmed.

Sources:

- <https://www.mobilemuster.com.au/>

- <https://www.mobilemuster.com.au/workplaces/>
- <https://www.mobilemuster.com.au/book-a-pickup/>

16.3 Batteries

Do not become a battery collection point in Phase 0.

B-cycle public drop points require:

- an accredited collector
- compliant collection container
- site risk assessment
- safety plan
- ongoing collection arrangement

Damaged/swollen batteries are excluded from ordinary B-cycle drop points.

Source:

- <https://bcycle.com.au/register/>

16.4 Local Dubbo downstream

Existing project research has traced Dubbo's historic/current e-waste pathway through the former Matthews operation / current Australian Metal Recycling presence at Mountbatten Drive.

Before relying on it, directly confirm:

- whether small commercial quantities are accepted
- categories
- lithium rules
- TVs/CRTs
- loose computer parts
- fees/rebates
- proof/certificate of recycling
- hours
- minimums

See MATTHEWS-INFRABUILD-AMR.md (MATTHEWS-INFRABUILD-AMR.md).

17. Do not rely on household disposal as the business backstop

The household Community Recycling Centre network is designed around household problem waste. A commercial refurb business should have its own legitimate downstream path rather than quietly feeding business rejects into a household service.

Likewise, never transport waste to a site unless it can lawfully accept that waste.

This is why the acceptance policy must be stricter than a council tip.

18. Insurance — probably the largest unknown unavoidable cash cost

Business.gov.au warns that standard home insurance often does not cover business activities and specifically identifies public liability as relevant where clients visit the home.

For the actual quote, disclose the real operation:

- home-based electronics refurbishment/reuse
- customer visits Tuesdays/Saturdays
- second-hand electronics stock
- laptops/phones/tablets with embedded lithium-ion batteries
- no loose battery collection
- no industrial shredding
- no outdoor stockpile
- online resale
- expected maximum stock
- whether any TV repair occurs
- whether data-bearing business devices are held

Ask for:

- public liability
- product liability
- business stock/tools cover
- fire implications
- customer property/data-bearing equipment implications
- effect on existing household/landlord insurance

Do not hide the e-waste/electronics aspect to get a cheap policy; a cheap policy that excludes the actual activity is not useful.

Source:

- business.gov.au — Home-based businesses:

<https://business.gov.au/Planning/Business-structures-and-types/Home-based-businesses>

19. Minimal business structure and fixed costs

If operating independently, a sole trader is the lowest-cost simple structure to test the model, subject to getting accounting/legal advice appropriate to the eventual risk.

Current verified government setup costs:

Item	Cost	Phase 0 decision
ABN	\$0	needed if independent business
Business name	\$47 / 1 yr or \$108 / 3 yrs	likely
Second-hand dealer licence	\$692 / 1 yr	only if Fair Trading says required
Scrap-metal registration	\$260 / 3 yrs	avoid activity initially unless required
Warehouse	\$0	do not lease
Employees	\$0	none
Dedicated truck	\$0	none
Website	\$0 initially	use simple/free channels
Public battery program	\$0	because do not offer it defer
Industrial recycling plant	\$0	never part of Phase 0

Source:

- business.gov.au — current business-name/sole-trader costs:

<https://business.gov.au/registrations/register-your-business-name>

Costs that remain genuinely unknown

- insurer premium
- landlord/agent requirements
- Council approval cost if activity is not exempt
- electrical safety/testing equipment/process
- storage changes needed to make the shed dry/safe
- downstream non-scheme recycling fees
- packing/postage materials
- repair parts float

Therefore no honest “total startup cost” can yet be given beyond:

If planning is exempt, second-hand licence is exempt/not required, the existing dry workspace and tools are usable, and downstream recycling is free/near-free, the cash floor can be very low — potentially mainly business-name registration, insurance and basic safety/storage consumables.

20. No-spend-before-answer list

Before buying shelving, signs, cages, branding or stock, resolve these in order.

Gate 1 — Council

Question: Is the exact selective Tue/Sat reuse/refurbishment model lawful as exempt home business at the property, or is it another land-use classification requiring consent?

Spend before answer: \$0

Gate 2 — premises/tenancy

Question: Is the intended shed area allowed to be used this way under the lease, and is it physically dry/secure enough for electronics?

Spend before answer: \$0

Gate 3 — Fair Trading

Question: Does the “recycling and rubbish collection programs” exemption apply when donated/collected electronics are triaged, refurbished and resold?

Spend before answer: do not pay \$692 yet

Gate 4 — insurance

Question: Who will insure this exact home activity, with customer visits and embedded lithium batteries, and for how much?

Spend before answer: quote only

Gate 5 — downstream

Question: Which Dubbo/NTCRS/MobileMuster partners will actually accept the project's rejects and on what terms?

Spend before answer: \$0

Only after these are clear should the project register/signage/advertising move to public launch.

21. Suggested Phase 0 public acceptance wording

This intentionally avoids promising to be a full waste facility:

Dubbo eWaste — electronics reuse intake
--

We rescue useful electronics for reuse, refurbishment and parts recovery.

Tuesday & Saturday — pre-approval required
--

Send the model, photos and condition before bringing anything.
--

We are interested in quality laptops, computers, phones, tablets, monitors, selected flat-screen TVs, consoles and other worthwhile electronics.
--

No general rubbish, no unattended drop-offs, no loose batteries, and damaged/swollen battery devices are not accepted.
--

We reserve the right to refuse any item.
--

Do not publish the residential address in general advertising until planning, lease and insurance questions are resolved. Use it only in confirmed intake instructions if/when lawful.

22. The first 30-item pilot

The earlier repo proposed 20–30 items. Keep the first experiment this small.

For each item measure:

- source
- device category
- age/model
- intake condition
- estimated value before acceptance
- time spent collecting/intaking
- data-wipe time
- repair time
- parts cost
- sale price
- selling fees
- postage/delivery cost
- days in stock
- final route
- recycling cost/rebate
- whether you would accept the same item again

Metrics after 30 items

Calculate:

- % sold whole
- % repaired then sold
- % used for parts
- % recycled
- % that became a liability
- gross revenue
- direct parts cost
- platform/postage cost
- downstream cost
- gross margin
- labour hours
- margin per labour hour
- median days-to-sale
- shelf space occupied
- most profitable categories
- worst categories

Phase 0 success test

Scale only if the pilot demonstrates:

- good equipment actually arrives
- inventory actually sells
- disposal remains controlled
- neighbour/customer traffic remains low
- stock stays within safe storage
- data workflow is manageable
- the business makes enough value to justify the time

23. Comparison with Joe's early Bendigo path

What is documented publicly about Joe:

- long prior technology experience
- started with his own e-waste
- then friends/family
- Bendigo E-Waste founded in early 2023
- formal entity/business-name/warehouse development followed later
- mature services came later

What is not documented well enough to assume:

- exact 2023 premises
- exact 2023 opening days
- original acceptance list
- original stock volume
- original insurance
- original planning approval
- original downstream recycler
- original margins
- whether Council supplied any early material
- whether he originally needed/held particular waste permits

Therefore the right lesson is not to copy today's warehouse.

It is to copy the sequence:

start with what you can safely understand and process → prove demand/supply → build buyer/downstream relationships → add services only after the economics and compliance are understood.

See `bendigo-benchmark.md` (`bendigo-benchmark.md`).

24. Recommended Phase 0 operating rules — one-page version

1. Pre-approval required.
2. Tuesday and Saturday intake only.
3. No unattended dumping.
4. No public waste bin.
5. No walk-in retail showroom.
6. Online sales first.
7. No loose batteries.
8. No damaged/swollen/wet/fire-affected battery devices.
9. TVs by prior approval only.
10. No CRTs.
11. No activation-locked devices for resale.
12. No item without a plausible reuse/parts/recycling route.
13. Every accepted item gets an intake ID.
14. Every data device starts in UNWIPED — RESTRICTED.
15. No data device enters resale/parts workflow until sanitisation is verified.
16. Every resale item gets a documented functional/safety/recall check.
17. Known defects are disclosed.
18. Use compliant chargers/power supplies only.
19. Nothing stored outdoors or visibly piled up.
20. Shelf full = intake paused.
21. No business scrap trading at launch.
22. No public battery-recycling service at launch.
23. No significant spending until Council + Fair Trading + insurer + downstream questions are answered.
24. No electronics inventory in a damp/unsafe shed.
25. Measure the first 30 items before scaling.

25. Remaining unknowns

Must resolve before public launch

- [] Council land-use classification for this exact model
- [] exact current statutory zoning/site constraints
- [] whether any DA/CDC/other consent is required
- [] tenancy/landlord position on this actual use
- [] whether the shed is sufficiently dry, secure and safe
- [] Fair Trading second-hand-dealer exemption applicability
- [] insurer willing to cover exact activity
- [] public/product liability premium

- [] Australian Metal Recycling exact accepted categories/terms
- [] NTCRS partner option in Dubbo
- [] MobileMuster collection-site terms for the business
- [] damaged battery downstream process
- [] electrical test/safety procedure appropriate to resale categories

Resolve during pilot

- [] actual supply of high-quality devices
- [] average resale value
- [] repair success rate
- [] buyer demand in Dubbo vs online
- [] selling-platform fees
- [] postage damage/return rate
- [] average labour per device
- [] storage days
- [] most/least profitable categories
- [] return/refund rate
- [] whether collections are worth offering
- [] whether businesses will pay for documented data erasure

Do not assume from Bendigo E-Waste

- [] Joe's early premises
- [] Joe's initial permits/licences
- [] Joe's original downstream recycler
- [] Joe's early profitability
- [] Joe's Council relationship
- [] Joe's initial intake rules

Ask Joe directly.

26. Primary sources used

Planning / waste classification

- NSW Planning Portal — Home-based enterprises

<https://www.planningportal.nsw.gov.au/development-and-assessment/planning-approval-pathways/exempt-development/home-based-enterprises>

- NSW Legislation — Standard Instrument planning definitions

<https://legislation.nsw.gov.au/>

- Dubbo Regional LEP 2022

<https://legislation.nsw.gov.au/>

- NSW EPA — Unlawful waste facility fine, 21 July 2026

<https://www.epa.nsw.gov.au/news/epamedia/260721-unlawful-waste-facility-hit-with-30-000-fine>

- NSW EPA — licensing thresholds

<https://www.epa.nsw.gov.au/Your-environment/Waste/waste-overview/licensing/reduced-licensing-thresholds>

Business / licences

- NSW Fair Trading — second-hand dealer licences and exemptions

<https://www.nsw.gov.au/business-and-economy/running-a-business/industry-specific-business-requirements/pawnbrokers-and-second-hand-dealers/pawnbroker-and-second-hand-dealer-licences>

- NSW Fair Trading — 2026-27 fees

<https://www.nsw.gov.au/business-and-economy/running-a-business/industry-specific-business-requirements/pawnbrokers-and-second-hand-dealers/pawnbrokers-and-second-hand-dealers-fees>

- NSW Fair Trading — second-hand dealer business obligations

<https://www.nsw.gov.au/business-and-economy/running-a-business/industry-specific-business-requirements/pawnbrokers-and-second-hand-dealers>

- NSW Police — Scrap Metal Industry

https://www.police.nsw.gov.au/online_services/scrap_metal_industry

- business.gov.au — Home-based businesses

<https://business.gov.au/Planning/Business-structures-and-types/Home-based-businesses>

- business.gov.au — business-name registration

<https://business.gov.au/registrations/register-your-business-name>

Safety / batteries

- Fire and Rescue NSW — damaged battery guidance

<https://www.fire.nsw.gov.au/fire-safety/home-fire-safety/battery-and-charging-safety/what-should-i-do-if-my-battery-is-damaged>

- B-cycle

<https://bcycle.com.au/>

- B-cycle drop-point requirements

<https://bcycle.com.au/register/>

- NSW — second-hand electrical appliances

<https://www.nsw.gov.au/housing-and-construction/safety-home/electrical-safety/buying-and-using-electrical-appliances>

- ACCC Product Safety — selling safe second-hand products

<https://www.productsafety.gov.au/business/know-how-to-sell-safe-products/how-to-sell-safe-second-hand-products-online>

Data

- Australian Cyber Security Centre — secure device disposal

<https://www.cyber.gov.au/protect-yourself/securing-your-devices/how-secure-your-device/how-dispose-your-device-securely>

- ASD ISM — media sanitisation

<https://www.cyber.gov.au/business-government/asds-cyber-security-frameworks/ism/cyber-security-guidelines/guidelines-for-media>

- NIST SP 800-88 Rev. 2

<https://csrc.nist.gov/pubs/sp/800/88/r2/final>

Downstream

- DCCEEW — NTCRS

<https://www.dcceew.gov.au/environment/protection/waste/product-stewardship/television-computer-recycling-scheme>

- DCCEEW — approved co-regulatory arrangements

<https://www.dcceew.gov.au/environment/protection/waste/product-stewardship/products-schemes/television-computer-recycling-scheme/coreg-arrangements>

- TechCollect — partner with us

<https://techcollect.com.au/our-partners/partner-with-us/>

- MobileMuster — workplaces

<https://www.mobilemuster.com.au/workplaces/>

Device viability

- Microsoft — Windows 10 end of support

<https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/windows/deployment/updates-lifecycle/windows-10-support-has-ended-on-october-14-2025>

- ACMA — 3G shutdown/device compatibility

<https://www.acma.gov.au/3g-network-switch>

- Apple — Activation Lock

<https://support.apple.com/en-au/108934>

- Google Android Help — device protection

<https://support.google.com/android/answer/9459346>

Bottom line

The minimum-cost launch is not “open the shed and take e-waste”.

It is:

resolve classification → make the shed genuinely suitable → pre-screen → accept only high-value/reusable devices → control data and batteries → sell online → use established downstream recyclers → measure 30 items → scale only if the numbers work.

That is the closest practical analogue to starting small rather than trying to reproduce a mature e-waste warehouse on day one.

27. Reuse-first benchmark adaptation

Deep research: REUSE-MODELS-PONYUP-RECONNECT-LAPTOP-INITIATIVE.md
(REUSE-MODELS-PONYUP-RECONNECT-LAPTOP-INITIATIVE.md).

Three Australian reuse organisations provide a useful design spectrum:

- PonyUp for Good: recent corporate fleets, strong chain-of-custody/data erasure, asset registers, remarketing and ESG reporting. Best analogue for future paid business ITAD.
- The Reconnect Project: deeper repair, donor-parts harvesting, refurbished retail and partner-agency distribution. Best analogue for the actual repair hierarchy, but too operationally broad for Phase 0.
- The Laptop Initiative: strict intake, mostly good ≤ 4 -year-old laptops, donor-prepared/wiped, rapid charity matching, minimal storage and no normal repair service. Best analogue for controlling stock and only accepting equipment with a destination.

Phase 0 rules reinforced by these benchmarks

1. Prefer recent corporate equipment over random household e-waste.
2. Ask the source for model/spec/condition before collection.
3. Record serial numbers and final outcomes from day one.
4. Build a sanitisation record even before offering enterprise-grade certificates.
5. Do not remove/destroy functioning drives unnecessarily if a secure erase can preserve whole-device reuse, subject to the agreed data standard.
6. Set a maximum age/spec gate for the default intake and make exceptions deliberately.
7. Know whether an item is headed for resale, repair, donor parts, social reuse or recycling before accepting it.
8. Keep stock moving; "shelf time" should be measured as a business metric.
9. Add a social donation stream only after the commercial pilot proves its workflow and partner agencies are identified.
10. Treat downstream material recycling as the final route, not the first evaluation step.

Longer-term service concept

If the pilot works, the most defensible future business-client service is:

Collection → serialised asset register → secure erase → test/grade → refurbish/reuse/resale → optional social redeployment → parts recovery → certified downstream recycling → client outcome report.

That model captures value before destruction while also solving the risk/compliance problem that causes businesses to use conventional IT disposal providers.